Essay review and submission guide

28 October 2026

The revised set contains two primary candidates and a conditional third. The accuracy and free-evidence essays have the clearest bounded formal contributions. The causation essay is now more defensible about its scope and has stronger finite verification, but its book-level originality comparison remains incomplete. The flattening essay remains withdrawn from the recommended set; no new version has resolved its central interpretation problem.

Manuscript	Words, excluding bibliography	Recommendation
Holistic Accuracy and the Lockean Thesis	4,937	Primary candidate
When Acting on Knowledge Makes Free Evidence Harmful	5,818	Primary candidate
What Normality Can and Cannot Do in Theories of Actual Causation	5,793	Conditional third candidate

The 6,000-word limit is a ceiling. The accuracy essay is shorter because padding it would weaken the presentation. The count includes appendices and footnotes. Mathematical notation makes counts differ slightly across software; each manuscript retains headroom.

What changed

Accuracy. Added a proved account of what increasing the perfect-record premium does: at fixed credences it favors broader core hypotheses and fewer beliefs, ultimately leaving only the tautology. Distinguished this from the claim that every positive premium admits some counterexample to a fixed threshold. Defined the assumptions behind the unique optimum. The strongest objection remains whether Dorst intended a stronger principle than order-independent evaluation of final belief states.

Free evidence. Strengthened the conditional-rule counterexample so the same rule governs future decisions. Added a simple three-state example and a proof of local stability under payoff changes. Removed an unsupported continuous-model extension. Distinguished fixed payoff ratios from absolute stakes, exact observation from partitional knowledge, and the value of following a later decision rule from a policy that can commit to ignore information.

Causation. Replaced criticisms that overstated the target's commitments with a precise result about uniform componentwise filters. Clarified the role of root variables, corrected a proof tuple, tested partial rankings and all candidate sizes, and explained what the isomorphic pair requires of richer representations. The causal contrast remains conditional on defending the coarse-grained judgments.

Verification and originality

The new accuracy checks covered 6,122 parameter points, with 150 full three-world belief-space comparisons. The free-evidence construction passed 3,306 finite defeat cases and 194 payoff-perturbation checks. The causation checks covered all 355 category preorders, with 2,130 calibration and 3,195 paired-case comparisons. No discrepancy was found. These

counts support specified formal claims; they do not measure philosophical quality or prove originality.

The closest comparisons inspected in this project include Dorst, Wang, Rothschild and Holguín for accuracy; Goodman and Salow, Salow, Geanakoplos, Das and Hong for free evidence; and Halpern, Halpern and Hitchcock, Gallow, Andreas and Günther and Beckers for causation. This final pass revisited the decisive formal passages and new claims, not every line of every cited source. No exhaustive novelty certification or independent expert acceptance is claimed. No new Claude or other-model report arrived on the checked branch after the previous review commit.

Outstanding source request: Halpern, Actual Causality (2016), preferably the book or chapters 3–4 plus pages 38–39. This matters to the originality of the causation result. The existing request also specifies pages 79–81 and 90–91. Please provide the PDF, without a summary or philosophical suggestions. The other two manuscripts do not depend on obtaining it.

Files to use

For each entry, submit its individual essay PDF and matching anonymized methodology PDF. The combined reading copy includes this non-anonymous workflow guide and is for personal review only; it is not the essay file to submit. The source archive contains the three manuscript sources, reports, revision differences and verification records. Historical drafts remain preserved in the repository.

Essay PDF	Matching report
Holistic-Accuracy-v3.pdf	A5-Methodology.pdf
Free-Evidence-v3.pdf	A6-Methodology.pdf
Causation-v3.pdf	A4-Methodology.pdf

Submission logistics

The official FAQ gives the deadline as **31 October 2026, 11:59 p.m. Anywhere on Earth**. The planned Saturday submission avoids relying on a timezone conversion. The rules allow up to three essays and require a separate anonymized methodology account for each. The FAQ allows its alternative form when OpenReview will not permit account creation, and asks entrants not to duplicate an entry across the two routes.

Use the latest individually named PDFs in this edition, preserve the original chat records, and make the final submission through the official page. No contest entry has been submitted by the assistant. The methodology reports disclose the available production history and its limits without exposing account identifiers or unrelated private material.

Official sources, checked 28 October 2026:

- https://www.zacharygoodsell.com/ai-philosophy-competition-faq
- https://www.zacharygoodsell.com/ai-philosophy-competition-rules